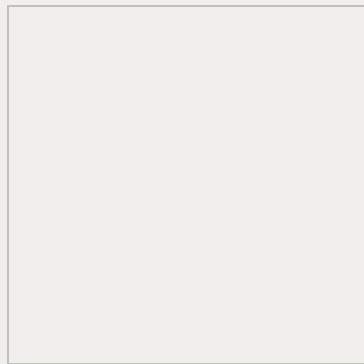


## IN CONTEXT

### Ballet maestro

Stravinsky's major contribution to ballet was about more than seizing the opportunity offered by Diaghilev to compose *The Firebird* as a fairy-tale spectacular, with the dance element grafted on. The tactile and rhythmic qualities in Stravinsky's music connected naturally with the technical and physical qualities of dance itself, as in *Petrushka* and *The Rite of Spring*. In 1947, he composed *Orpheus* for choreography by another Russian exile, George Balanchine, who then became artistic director of New York City Ballet. Besides choreographing many of Stravinsky's concert-hall works, Balanchine also commissioned *Agon*, premiered by NYCB in 1957.



ORPHEUS, CHOREOGRAPHED BY GEORGE BALANCHINE, IN NEW  
YORK

Igor Fyodorovich Stravinsky was born into a musical household in Oranienbaum, on the outskirts of St. Petersburg, in June 1882. He later said that the Russian imperial capital was “dearer to my heart than any [city] in the world.” Nonetheless, he always insisted that his early years had been unhappy and his school days